

Prehistoric Britain – Lesson 1

Which animals lived during the Ice Age?

Subject Knowledge Notes

The Pleistocene Epoch is defined as the time period that began about 2.6 million years ago and lasted until about 11,700 years ago. The most recent Ice Age occurred then, as glaciers covered huge parts of the planet Earth. There have been at least five documented major ice ages during the 4.6 billion years since the Earth was formed — and most likely many more before humans came on the scene about 2.3 million years ago. The Pleistocene Epoch is the first in which Homo sapiens evolved, and by the end of the epoch humans could be found in nearly every part of the planet.

At the time of the Pleistocene, the continents had moved to their current positions. At one point during the Ice Age, sheets of ice covered all of Antarctica, large parts of Europe, North America, and South America, and small areas in Asia. In North America they stretched over Greenland and Canada and parts of the northern United States. The remains of glaciers of the Ice Age can still be seen in parts of the world, including Greenland and Antarctica.

While Homo sapiens evolved, many vertebrates, especially large mammals, succumbed to the harsh climate conditions of this period.

One of the richest sources of information about life in the Pleistocene Epoch can be found in the La Brea Tar Pits in Los Angeles, where remains of everything from insects to plant life to animals were preserved, including a partial skeleton of a female human and a nearly complete woolly mammoth. In addition to the woolly mammoth, mammals such as saber-toothed cats (Smilodon), giant ground sloths (Megatherium) and mastodons roamed the Earth during this period. Other mammals that thrived during this period include moonrats, tenrecs (hedgehog-like creatures) and macrauchenia (similar to a llamas and camels).

Although many vertebrates became extinct during this period, mammals that are familiar to us today — including apes, cattle, deer, rabbits, kangaroos, wallabies, bears, and members of the canine and feline families — could be found during this time. Other than a few birds that were classified as dinosaurs, most notably the Titanis, there were no dinosaurs during the Pleistocene Epoch. They had become extinct at the end of the Cretaceous Period, more than 60 million years before the Pleistocene Epoch began.

Birds flourished during this period, including members of the duck, geese, hawk and eagle families. There were also some flightless birds such as ostriches, rheas and moas. The flightless birds did not fare as well, as they had to compete with mammals and other creatures for limited supplies of food and water, as a good portion of the water was frozen. Crocodiles, lizards, turtles, pythons and other reptiles also thrived during this period. As for vegetation, it was fairly limited in many areas. There were some scattered conifers, including pines, cypress and yews, along with some broadleaf trees such as beeches and oaks. On the ground, there were prairie grasses as well as members of the lily, orchid and rose families.

Adapted from Live Science: <https://www.livescience.com/40311-pleistocene-epoch.html>

Further Reading:

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Last_Glacial_Period

<https://www.bbc.co.uk/earth/story/20150722-lost-beasts-of-the-ice-age>

Videos:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Pgmdl1Xr3hQ>

Lesson Two: Which animals lived during the Ice Age?



5 mins

- Display and read the lesson question (slide 2).
- Display the retrieval quiz (slide 4). Explain that pupils should try and remember these answers from last lesson.
- If they are unsure they should take their best guess and move on to the next question.
- Answers should be completed independently.
- Reveal answers on slide 5 and pupils should self-mark and correct.

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Which animals lived during the Ice Age?

 5 mins	• Read A frozen planet. • Note that life on earth would have been very different and harsh. • The ice would have changed the way humans behaved, and where they travelled. • Animals had adapted to live in this different world.
 10 mins	• Watch the video which explains the Ice Age: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dJ5GYQrkvxl (slide 6) • Note that these are called glacial ages, because huge ice sheets known as glaciers covered the earth. • Point out that Antarctica is still covered in a large ice sheet. • Show map of earth during the Ice Age (slide 7) and ask pupils to draw other glaciers on their map.
 5 mins	• Continue reading about the animals of the Ice Age. • Ask pupils to list different reasons animals might have gone extinct (slide 8). • Note that there were likely many factors and we can't be sure which was the most important, they probably worked in combination. • These could include changes in climate, food scarcity, human hunting, competition with other species, increased predators, loss of habitat.
 10 mins	• Continue reading about the Woolly Mammoth. • Ask pupils to discuss whether we should bring back the woolly mammoth. • Draw attention to some of the human behaviours which allowed us to hunt large animals. • Ask pupils to list the advantages and disadvantages of hunting woolly mammoths, then hold a small debate.
 15 mins	• Display the pictures of the animals that lived in Britain during the Ice Age (slide 9). • Note that all of these animals are now extinct. • Ask pupils to look carefully at the pictures and write descriptions of their features. • You may like to link these to how the animal had adapted to the cold conditions.
 5 mins	• Return to page 3 and ask pupils to complete their learning review by answering the key question for the lesson.